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Guide for the Study Guide

Letters from the Chair

It is our honor to welcome you to the United Nations General Assembly at JMUN 2026. My name is Santiago Cabrera, and I'll be the Chair for this committee. MUN is where we learn to think under pressure, defend ideas with precision, and negotiate with people who may fundamentally disagree with us. I have experienced that growth myself, and it is an honor to now serve as your chair for this committee. The topics are: Deforestation of the Amazon rainforest and combating human trafficking networks in South America. It's not abstract. It is real, regional, and deeply complex. I really hope that you will learn and enjoy this experience. Best wishes and regards to all delegates.

Letter from the Co-Chair

Welcome to JMUN 2026! My name is Andrea Sorensen, and I'll be the co-chair of this committee. We're going to discuss the deforestation of the Amazon rainforest and human trafficking in South America. Do not be afraid to speak up with your thoughts and share your ideas, as well as to give it your best effort! This will be an excellent experience to learn new skills, boost your self-confidence, and work effectively as a group. Every idea counts and has the potential to create change.

COUNTRY MATRIX

Bolivia
Brazil
China
Colombia

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Democratic Republic of Congo
Ecuador
France
Germany
Ghana
Indonesia
Mexico
Nigeria
Russia
USA
Venezuela

Committee Introduction; Attributions of the Committee

The United Nations General Assembly (GA) was established in 1945 with the signing of the UN Charter, located at the United Nations Headquarters in New York, USA. It is unique as it includes representatives from all 193 member states, meaning that it gives each country one vote, not taking into account the size or the population of the country, making it the most inclusive assembly in the UN, as all nations can debate global issues equally.

Throughout history, the General Assembly has achieved a lot of milestones and achievements. In 1948, it played an important role in creating the Declaration of Human Rights, which set the standard of treating everyone fairly and equally. In addition, it has also supported the independence of more than 80 former colonies, helping many nations gain freedom. Besides this, it also contributed to international peace and security by approving budgets for UN peacekeeping missions. In 2015, the Sustainable Development Goals were

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approved, which guided global efforts to reduce poverty as well as protect the environment.

Nowadays, the General Assembly addresses many different global issues, such as human rights, climate change, and poverty reduction.

Topic A: Deforestation of the Amazon Rainforest

Topic introduction

One of the most biodiverse ecosystems on the planet is the Amazon rainforest with an area of around 5.5 million square kilometers in nine South American countries (Brazil, Peru, Colombia, Bolivia, Venezuela, Ecuador, Guyana, Suriname, and French Guiana). The rainforest has been called "the lungs of the earth" because of its vital function in regulating the earth's climate through the exchange of carbon dioxide and oxygen in the atmosphere. Furthermore, the Amazon rainforest boasts a huge amount of biodiversity with an estimated ten percent of all the species in the world living within it and hundreds of indigenous tribes dependent on it.

However, the Amazon rainforest faces a serious problem of deforestation. In general, deforestation involves the clearance of forests for permanent human utilization of the land previously occupied by these forests. Deforestation in the Amazon rainforest occurs mainly due to human interference and consists of the following actions: Cattle ranching (accounts for almost 80% of deforestation in the Amazonian rainforest), agriculture (farming and grazing land), etc.

The destruction of the forests is having a huge effect on society, contributing to Global Climate Change. The forests act as stores of carbon dioxide and, in their destruction, release all that carbon back into the environment as greenhouse gases. In addition, the destruction caused by the logging also results in the extinction of many plants and animal species, as well as jeopardizing the lives and culture of many indigenous societies.

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There have been various attempts, both national and international, to preserve the forests and the biodiversity present within them. Governments around the world have adopted environmental policies that prevent deforestation from taking place, while there have been various international agreements such as the Paris Agreement, where many countries have pledged themselves to reduce the effect of climate change around the globe and preserve the forest cover. There have been a number of organizations like the United Nations and World Wildlife Fund who have introduced conservation initiatives in order to preserve the forest cover; however, the implementation of the same has been rather poor because of inconsistent regulation.

● **Definition of Key Terms**

Deforestation: The permanent removal of forests so that the land can be used by humans for other purposes

Amazon rainforest: The largest forest in the world, located in South America. Known as the lungs of the earth.

Biodiversity: Variety of plant and animal life in an ecosystem

Climate change: Long-term changes in global climate and weather patterns mainly caused by human activities

History of the Topic

Deforestation of the Amazon started increasing in the 1960s due to the government of Brazil's efforts to encourage economic development of the area through the construction of "Trans-Amazonian Highway". The construction facilitated access to areas far from the roads and led to deforestation because people could now conduct activities such as farming, cattle ranching, and logging easily. Demand for products produced in the area such as beef and soy

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increased, hence accelerating deforestation by the end of the 1990s and the beginning of the 2000s, especially by China. Various actors have contributed to the problem ranging from the governments of different nations, private firms, native tribes, and international organizations all having various interests. Between 2004 and 2012, deforestation was greatly reduced in the region after new stringent laws were implemented by Brazil; however, deforestation increased again by 2015. This happened because of poor law enforcement and other economic reasons. Deforestation in the area can also be traced to international agreements such as the Paris agreement, which was held within the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change.

Discussion of the Topic

Aim to discuss the issues within the topic. Even though the history of the topic provides context, the discussion of the topic will look at the most controversial issues within the topic itself. International conflicts are generally caused by a multitude of problems. Therefore, looking at the controversial issues countries are facing will inform delegates on what the major problems are. While you might have highlighted the history of UN actions in the previous sections, this is the section to debate whether these actions have been effective or not, along with the legality of state practice. It is also worth considering the political objectives and motivations of individual actors within the most affected regions of your topic: from international organizations and NGOs, to member states.

- **Block Positions**

1. **Resource-Dependent States**

   (Brazil, Bolivia, Colombia, Venezuela, Ecuador)

   These countries are directly affected and prioritize economic development through agriculture, mining, and infrastructure. They support environmental protection in principle but strongly defend national sovereignty and resist strict international regulations. Enforcement is also achallengee due to illegal activities and weak state presence in remote areas.

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2. **Developed Environmental Advocates**

   (France, Germany, United States, Mexico)

   These countries emphasize the seriousness of climate change, biodiversity protection, and sustainability. They support international agreements, funding mechanisms, and stronger environmental regulations.

3. **Sovereignty-Focused Powers**

   (China, Russia)

   These states prioritize economic growth, trade, and access to resources. They generally avoid supporting strict environmental restrictions and emphasize non-interference in domestic affairs. Their demand for raw materials indirectly contributes to deforestation.

4. **Developing States**

   (Democratic Republic of the Congo, Indonesia, Ghana, Nigeria)

   These countries face similar environmental challenges in their own regions. They support conservation but emphasize the need for development and international financial support. They often align with Amazon states in opposing strict external pressure.

Bolivia	Bolivia supports sustainable development but prioritizes economic growth through resource extraction. It maintains that developed countries should provide financial support for conservation efforts.
Brazil	Brazil emphasizes national sovereignty over the Amazon while balancing environmental protection with economic development, particularly in agriculture and

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	infrastructure.
China	China supports economic development and trade stability, maintaining that environmental policies should not restrict growth or interfere with national sovereignty.
Colombia	Colombia supports environmental conservation but highlights challenges in enforcement due to illegal activities and limited state control in remote regions.
Democratic Republic of Congo	The DRC advocates for rainforest protection but stresses that developing countries require financial assistance to achieve conservation goals.
Ecuador	Ecuador supports environmental protection but continues to rely on resource extraction, particularly oil, for economic stability.
France	France strongly supports strict environmental protection measures, international agreements, and increased global accountability for deforestation.
Germany	Germany promotes strong climate policies and supports financial and technical assistance to reduce deforestation globally.
Ghana	Ghana supports environmental protection while emphasizing the importance of economic development and balanced policy approaches.
Indonesia	Indonesia supports a balanced approach between conservation and development, emphasizing national sovereignty in environmental decision-making.

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Mexico	Mexico supports regional cooperation on environmental issues but prioritizes domestic economic growth and internal security concerns.
Nigeria	Nigeria supports development-focused environmental policies and emphasizes the need for international support for conservation efforts.
Russia	Russia prioritizes economic interests and national sovereignty, generally opposing strict international environmental regulations.
USA	The United States supports environmental protection and international cooperation while balancing economic and domestic policy considerations.
Venezuela	Venezuela emphasizes sovereignty and economic stability, with limited capacity to enforce environmental protections.

- **Previous Attempts to Solve the Problem**

A number of national and international initiatives have been implemented by governments across the world aiming at deforestation reduction in the Amazon. The Paris Agreement adopted in 2015 under the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change represents one of the largest agreements that has had global effect. The agreement aimed at encouraging countries to minimize their greenhouse gas emissions and preserve forests as natural carbon sinks. Although many Amazonian countries undertook the responsibility to limit deforestation within the terms of the agreement, the initiative failed due to its voluntariness and lack of control.

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The other important global initiative that was launched by the UN in order to minimize emissions and protect natural resources is known as REDD+. The program implies the provision of financial rewards to the countries that agree to undertake necessary actions aimed at the protection of forested areas and limitation of their emission. Such Amazonian countries as Brazil and Peru have agreed to participate in the program and received funding for their conservation activities. However, the program faced some problems, among which were difficulties in monitoring outcomes, corruption, uneven funding distribution, and lack of commitment.

At the national scale, one of the most successful approaches used by Brazil against deforestation from 2004 to 2012 is represented by the Action Plan for Prevention and Control of Deforestation in the Legal Amazon (PPCDAm). This approach included the use of remote sensing data, improved law enforcement, and an increase in the number of protected areas. As a consequence, deforestation rates were decreased significantly during this period. Nevertheless, this positive trend has not been maintained since 2015 due to a lack of control, new political realities, and economic factors. This example proves the fact that proper policies can be successful but require constant monitoring.

The financial mechanism of funding includes the work of the Amazon Fund, which includes contributions from other states such as Norway and Germany. Despite the fact that many projects have been financed through the Amazon Fund, its effectiveness has been hindered by political differences and other barriers.

Topic B: Combating Human Trafficking in South America

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Introduction of the Topic:

Human trafficking in South America is an extensive problem affecting thousands of people annually, especially those who belong to disadvantaged groups like migrants, women, and children. The continent acts as a source, transit point, and destination for trafficking networks, implying that the individuals involved are usually lured in one country, moved via another, and exploited in a third country. According to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, human trafficking in South America revolves around two forms of exploitation, including sexual slavery and forced labor, with many victims being trafficked domestically or interregionally.

Human trafficking in South America is associated with social factors such as poverty, economic disparity, political unrest, and migration. Over the past few years, human rights crises like the massive migration of people from Venezuela have raised the number of potential victims, with millions leaving their homes without adequate legal or financial security. Such situations increase the chances of people being tricked or coerced by traffickers. Trafficking networks usually operate with the involvement of organized crime groups or transnational organizations that control smuggling routes.

The consequences of human trafficking transcend the experiences of individuals and reach the society as a whole, since victims are forced to work in agriculture, mining, or domestic labor or used for sex. Trafficking may often be hard to prove because of widespread corruption, poor law enforcement, and clandestine operations of traffickers. In Latin America and the Caribbean alone, in 2022, there were over 4,000 reported cases of human trafficking victims, which, however, comprise just a small part of all the victims.

There are a number of national and international measures aimed at tackling the problem of human trafficking. The Palermo Protocol has provided the framework for anti-trafficking actions on three key fronts, namely prevention, protection, and prosecution of offenders, while other global bodies, such as the UN and various NGOs, are implementing their programs that help combat this phenomenon. Nevertheless, despite all these efforts, human trafficking becomes increasingly difficult to tackle due to a variety of socio-economic factors.

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Definitions of Terms:

Human trafficking: The movement of humans by coercing, defrauding, or deceiving them for various exploitative purposes such as forced labor, sexual exploitation, and even slavery. Human trafficking is a term coined by the United Nations in its Palernero Protocol.

Forced labor: This entails labor performed involuntarily by the threat of coercion.

Sexual trafficking: This encompasses the exploitation of individuals through forced prostitution or any other form of sexual exploitation.

Cartels/organized crime: This entails highly organized criminal organizations based mainly in Mexico and Colombia, which are engaged in drug trafficking; however, they have expanded their operations to include human trafficking and smuggling.

Kidnapping: This refers to the unlawful abduction, detention, or transportation of an individual by coercion or deception.

Vulnerable populations: Individuals who are at greater risk of being trafficked, such as females, minors, migrants, and impoverished persons.

History of the Topic

The roots of exploitation in South America date back to colonial-era slavery, which created lasting social hierarchies and economic inequality. By the early 2000s, trafficking became more professional. The economic collapse of **Venezuela** triggered a massive exodus, with the **2026 Refugee and Migrant Response Plan** estimating that over **5.37 million** people are currently in need of assistance. Criminal groups like **Tren de Aragua** prey on these migrants using "debt bondage," charging them for travel and then forcing them into labor or sex work to pay off the debt. Today, an estimated **5.1 million people** in the Americas live in conditions of modern slavery. The 44% of trafficking victims are used in forced labor such as mines,

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farms, and construction, 36% into sexualexploitationn, and the rest of the people are forced into begging, child exploitation, and criminal activities. This is possible because of the mass displacement of people, who then, "coyotes" and drug cartels, who realized they could use their existing smuggling routes to move people as easily as they moved narcotics.
There is no exact single number for kidnappings tied to trafficking, but criminal groups in South America regularly use kidnapping as recruitment or toexertt control over individua. Anotherer core example would be in migration routes. In the Darién Gap, 214 sexual violence cases in a single month, that's 1 assault every 3.5 hours, **ONLY** in reported cases. Over **7.7 million Venezuelans** have migrated due tothe crisis, but even more unreported moves across: Colombia, Peru, Ecuador, and Chile, tens of thousands of victims are trafficked yearly. Some reports suggest that human trafficking generates as much or more revenue than drugs in some areas. The UN states some potential reasons for trafficking as: Economic crisis, migration, weak law enforcement, corruption, and organized crime expansion.

In the present day, trafficking is no longer a "side business" for cartels; it is a core revenue stream. Organizations like the **Sinaloa Cartel**, **PCC (Brazil)**, and the **CJNG (Mexico)** have diversified into a "portfolio" of crime ,including money laundering and extortion. These groups are decentralized. They do not rely on a single leader to function, allowing trafficking networks to remain operational despite leadership losses.

International law began catching up with the **Palermo Protocol (2000)**, which defined trafficking as a global crime. Regionally, the **Quito Process (2018)** saw 13 Latin American nations agree to share intelligence specifically regarding the Venezuelan exodus. Despite these frameworks and the efforts of the UNODC, the scale remains massive: an estimated **5.1 million people** in the Americas live in modern slavery. Modern efforts now focus on "The Three Ps": **Prevention** of recruitment, **Protection** of survivors, and **Prosecution** of the criminal networks.

Discussion of the Topic

Some of the most controversial aspects of human trafficking in South America are the role of organized crime and the ability of governments to control it. Criminal groups &

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organizations in Mexico, Colombi,a and Brazl, operate across borders andoftenn have greater resources than local law enforcement, which raises questions about state capacity and control. An example of this would be the operation that killed El Mencho, as the cartel's rapid and coordinated violent response across multiple regions demonstrated that removing leadership does not dismantle trafficking systems. Another issue within this is migrations, since many victims are migrants who lack legal protection, which makes them more vulnerable to human trafficking and kidnappings. The effectiveness of agreements is also debated, as the Palermo Protocol relies on national enforcement, which varies from country to country. There are differences between short-term solutions with security strategies, and long-term approaches that focus on reducing the inequality that causes human trafficking. These disagreements reflect deeper questions about responsibility, sovereignty, and the most effective way to combat trafficking in a region where organized crime remains highly adaptable.

- **Block Positions**

1. **High-Impact Regional States (Source, Transit, and Crime-Affected)**
   (Brazil, Colombia, Venezuela, Ecuador, Bolivia, Mexico)
   These countries are the most directly affected by human trafficking, either as source, transit, or destination points. Trafficking in these states is closely linked to organized crime, migration flows, and economic inequality. Governments focus on strengthening law enforcement, controlling borders, and dismantling criminal networks, but face major challenges such as corruption, limited resources, and weak institutional capacity.
2. **Destination andEnforcement-Orientedd States**
   (United States, France, Germany)
   These countries are primary destinations for trafficking victims and focus on reducing demand, strengthening legal frameworks, and improving international cooperation. They invest in anti-trafficking programs, intelligence sharing, and victim protection systems.
3. **Global and Comparative States**

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(China, Russia, Nigeria, Indonesia, Ghana, Democratic Republic of the Congo)

These countries are less directly involved in South American trafficking but provide a broader global perspective. Many face their own trafficking challenges and emphasize sovereignty, development, and internal enforcement.

Bolivia	Bolivia recognizes human trafficking as a major domestic issue linked to poverty and rural vulnerability, particularly in forced labor sectors such as mining and agriculture, and supports strengthening enforcement and victim protection.
Brazil	Brazil acknowledges its role as a source, transit, and destination country and prioritizes combating organized crime networks, while facing ongoing challenges in enforcement and internal trafficking.
China	China supports international cooperation against trafficking while emphasizing national sovereignty and state-led enforcement, maintaining an indirect role in South American trafficking dynamics.
Colombia	Colombia recognizes trafficking as linked to internal conflict, migration, and organized crime, and supports strengthening law enforcement and international cooperation to address cross-border networks.
Democratic Republic of Congo	The DRC highlights trafficking as a consequence of instability and poverty, advocating for international support and capacity-building to address exploitation and protect vulnerable populations.

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Ecuador	Ecuador acknowledges its role as a transit country, particularly due to migration flows, and supports improving border control and regional cooperation to reduce trafficking risks.
France	France views human trafficking as a human rights violation and supports strong international cooperation, legal enforcement, and victim protection frameworks to combat the issue globally.
Germany	Germany prioritizes prevention, victim support, and international collaboration, advocating for stronger enforcement mechanisms and coordinated global responses to trafficking.
Ghana	Ghana recognizes trafficking as linked to labor exploitation and child trafficking, supporting international cooperation while emphasizing development-focused solutions to reduce vulnerability.
Indonesia	Indonesia addresses trafficking through migration control and labor protections, supporting stronger enforcement while emphasizing the importance of regulating migration flows.
Mexico	Mexico recognizes trafficking as closely linked to migration and organized crime, prioritizing border control, dismantling criminal networks, and strengthening regional cooperation.
Nigeria	Nigeria acknowledges its role as a major source country, particularly for transnational trafficking networks, and focuses on prevention, law enforcement,

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	and international cooperation.
Russia	Russia emphasizes national sovereignty and internal enforcement in addressing trafficking, supporting international cooperation while limiting external involvement in domestic policies.
USA	The United States identifies itself as a major destination country and prioritizes law enforcement, border control, and international partnerships to combat trafficking networks.
Venezuela	Venezuela recognizes trafficking as a consequence of economic crisis and mass migration, with many citizens becoming vulnerable to exploitation both domestically and abroad.

- **Relevant UN Treaties, Resolutions, and Reports**

Palermo Protocol (2000)
https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/human-trafficking/protocol.html

UN Global Report on Trafficking in Persons – United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime
https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/data-and-analysis/glotip.html

UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime – United Nations
https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/organized-crime/intro/UNTOC.html

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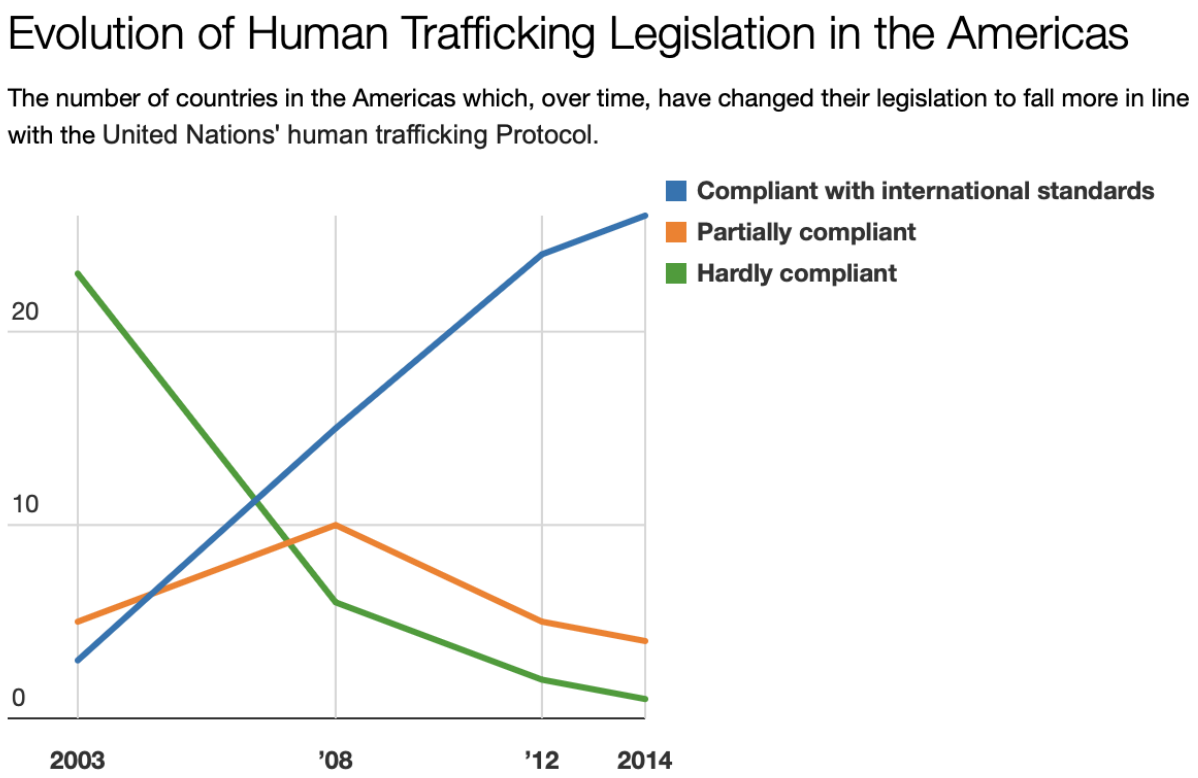
- **Previous Attempts to Solve the Problem**

Efforts to combat human trafficking have included national legislation, international agreements, and operations against organized crime. The Palermo Protocol established a global framework for prevention, protection, and prosecution. The UNODC (United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime) have supported enforcement and awareness "Out of the 31 countries surveyed in the Americas, 26 now have anti-human trafficking laws that are compliant with these standards. This is a stark contrast to 2003 when just three Latin American countries were compliant, as indicated in the chart below." https://insightcrime.org/news/analysis/latin-america-success-unodc-human-trafficking/



"According to the UNODC, just 10 percent of all suspects investigated on human trafficking charges in the Americas were actually convicted. The only Latin American country to see more than 50 human trafficking convictions between 2010 and 2012 was Peru. During that same time period, some countries in Central America and the Caribbean failed to convict anyone."

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https://insightcrime.org/news/analysis/latin-america-success-unodc-human-trafficking/

- **Objectives**

- Reduce human trafficking across South America.
- Improve protection, identification, and support system for victims.
- Address root causes such as poverty, inequality, and migration vulnerability.
- Disrupt organized crime networks involved in trafficking activities.

- **Guiding Questions**

- How can countries improve cooperation across borders to prevent trafficking?
- How can corruption and weak enforcement be addressed in affected regions?

- Should military and security operations be prioritized over social and economic solutions?
- What measures can be taken to better protect migrants from exploitation?

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Organization of American States. *Trafficking in Persons in the Americas*.
https://www.oas.org/en/topics/human_trafficking.asp

Insight Crime. Latin America's Success (and Struggles) in Fighting Human Trafficking.
https://insightcrime.org/news/analysis/latin-america-success-unodc-human-trafficking/

- **Further Reading**

Human Rights Watch reports on trafficking and migration
https://www.hrw.org/topic/refugees-and-migrants